

Feature Spec — Geofenced Discovery + Live Local Facts

EventCarpooling · additions to the existing digest engine · July 2026

The idea: add radius-based discovery and live local facts to the existing digest — while avoiding the two parts of the "active Nextdoor" vision that sink companies: a social feed and an SMB ad marketplace.

The guiding rule: ship **data** features, not **social** features. Data works on day one with zero neighbors participating. A feed of user posts is empty until a whole neighborhood shows up — that is the cold-start trap.

Module 1 — Geofenced radius discovery **BUILD FIRST**

Instead of one city-wide list, the reader anchors to their home address and sees events ranked by distance within a radius they choose (1, 3, or 5 miles).

Reader-facing behavior

- Set-once anchor location, saved per subscriber
- Radius toggle: 1 / 3 / 5 miles (default 3)
- Events sorted nearest-first, each showing distance ("0.4 mi")
- Optional "walkable" filter (≤ 1 mile)

Build notes

- Geocode each venue to coordinates at ingestion; cache it
- Haversine distance against the subscriber's anchor — no live GPS needed for the email
- Personalized send via merge tags or a light send layer
- Effort: moderate. The geocoding pipeline is the real work; the math is trivial. It also improves the current digest immediately.

Operator value: "Every subscriber gets events near *their* door, not just downtown."

Module 2 — Live local facts **EXPERIMENT SECOND**

A small "Near you right now" section carrying live civic *data* — not events, not user posts.

Candidate signals, by feasibility

- **ER / urgent-care wait times** — the strongest idea from the brainstorm, where a hospital or clinic publishes them

- **Vet / pet-ER wait times** — same pattern where available
- **Road closures / transit alerts / weather advisories** — reliable public feeds (city open data, 511, NWS)
- **Today-only happenings** — pop-ups and markets, surfaced apart from the weekly list

Hard rules: every item shows source + last-updated time; only display a signal where a real feed exists (no estimates, no crowdsourcing — that is where accuracy and liability problems start); it is information, never advice.

Why separate from events: different update cadence (live vs weekly), different trust bar, different failure mode. Keep it visually distinct so a bad feed can be pulled without touching the digest. Start with ONE signal in ONE metro, measure, then expand.

Out of scope — the Nextdoor trap

- **User-generated feeds / posts / comments** — require neighborhood-wide density to not be empty; the cold-start problem that keeps hyperlocal social perpetually hard.
- **SMB advertiser marketplace** (roofers, mechanics, agents paying to post) — Nextdoor's core business, which Nextdoor *still struggles to sell at 40M+ users*. Do not enter their hardest market with none of their scale.
- **Real-time GPS safety-alert layer** — Citizen's model; heavy moderation, liability, and trust burden.

Sequencing

- 1 — Geocode the event pipeline (prerequisite; also improves the digest now)
- 2 — Ship radius discovery to Austin; measure open/click lift vs city-wide
- 3 — Add ONE live-facts signal as a distinct block; measure whether "near you now" lifts opens
- 4 — Expand to operator cities only after Austin shows lift

Success metric: does "near me / live now" beat the static city digest on opens, clicks, and forwards? If yes, it is a durable edge over both beehiiv (no local data) and a generic events list. If no, it stays a minor feature and the operator model remains the main line.

EventCarpooling — internal strategy note. Figures and competitor references are directional and should be re-verified before external use.